Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Philip Levine's "Gospel"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of sensory imagery as it contributes to the theme of Philip Levine's "Gospel" include

diction,
imagery,
irony,
metaphor,
rhetorical question,
theme, and
tone.

The young writer's approach to a discussion of the sensory imagery of Levine's "Gospel" might turn on a recognition that imagery controls the tone of the poem and thus supports the isolation and, to some degree, the helplessness that is central to the speaker's experience, a sentiment coloring the speaker's final observation, "How weightless / words are when nothing will do" (lines 30-31).

The student of Anglo-Saxon poetry might sense the poem's thematic and tonal kinship with the elegies of the Anglo-Saxon canon he or she has read this season. That this kinship is somehow the focus of a tie-breaking essay should not make that essay automatically or necessarily a better essay this season. The connection would, indeed, be a happy one; however, the tie-breaking prompt does not point the contestant in that direction.

The contestant might appreciate the positioning of the metaphor that is the question "What did I bring / to the dance?" (lines 18-19). The speaker has wandered through a natural world that reinforces a meditative brooding, and, caught up in the natural imagery of memory (lines 14-18), the speaker dwells on a question regarding his own contribution: "What did I bring / to the dance?" What follows the rhetorical question turns on the immediate and distant crushed letter (line 20) in his pocket.

Something might be made of the poem's title "good news" and the poem's last line, which essentially contradicts or denies the efficacy of words (good news). Perhaps the natural world acts as both reminder of the inefficacy, the inadequacy, of words and solace in the face of this inadequacy, part of the irony being that it is the poem, as a collection of words that work, arguably, toward—through sensory imagery—a calming (line 28) that has been used to explore the inadequacy.